UK Data Service

Curating qualitative research data for TREs: the UKDS perspective

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Qualitative data curation at the UKDS

- Around 2,000 studies in the UKDS catalogue with a qualitative element (mixed-methods or fully qualitative)
- Mostly subject to Safeguarded access (UKDS End-User-Licence or Special Licence Access)
- Mainly sets of interview transcripts
- A few instances of social media data
- Audio and video data generally accepted for archival purposes only (difficult and resource-intensive to anonymise, large size)

Qualitative curation – the first stage

- Process begins at acquisition stage before data arrive; dialogue with data owner:
  - Advise on disclosure control – if early enough in project, discuss informed consent and participants' agreement to archiving
  - Level of detail in materials; emphasis strongly on data owner and their research team to undertake necessary disclosure-related edits **before deposit**
  - Don't remove too much detail and reduce research utility – adjust access control instead
- Once data arrive, Curation team carry out assessment prior to processing:
  - Disclosure review of all materials. Check that agreed pseudonymisation and other disclosure control edits with the data owner have been done, and applied consistently
  - Basic formatting checks, ensure collection is complete and all materials have been sent
  - Ensure documentation is sufficient and comprehensive enough to enable secondary user to make informed analysis

Assessing disclosure risk in qualitative data: standard access

Disclosure review:

- Direct identifiers, including file properties information
  - personal names, place and company names, street or other location names, phone numbers, email addresses, etc.

- Indirect identifiers: elements of text that could reveal interviewee's identity, either alone or combined with social media or other data
  - detailed information on employment/workplaces, educational institutions/qualifications, occupations of other family members, personal circumstances and detailed geographical locations, e.g.

  '*I won the National Lottery. I was the only winner in North East England last year.*'

  '*I live in the converted windmill in the centre of the village. It's the only windmill painted red in the whole of East Anglia.*'

- Remove or anonymise?

Assessing disclosure risk in qualitative data in the UKDS TRE

- For quantitative secure access data, generally only direct identifiers are removed – data are 'de-identified'- so in theory we do not remove indirect identifiers
- Does this approach work for qualitative data? How does it fit in with the 5 Safes?
  - Safe projects: research projects are approved by data owners for the public good ✓
  - Safe people: researchers are trained and authorised to use data safely ✓
  - Safe settings: a SecureLab environment prevents unauthorised use ✓
  - Safe outputs: screened and approved outputs that are non-disclosive ✓
  - Safe data: data are treated to protect confidentiality ?
- For the examples given, some anonymisation may still be needed for qualitative data held in a TRE, but how much?
- Qualitative data suitable for a TRE may be sensitive: personal/organisational
- Consider informed consent: are participants happy that the other safeguards are strong enough to allow fully detailed data to be available?

Qualitative data in the UKDS TRE: starting the journey

Long history of archiving qualitative data, preparing to trial it in UKDS TRE. (Other TREs may have made more progress, happy to discuss and learn.)

- Resource-intensive processing
- AI solutions for anonymisation? Must be offline, local installation
- Trial Textwash/Famtafos - most interview transcripts in Word, still supports .txt only. Conversion takes time and loses formatting
- Training needed for output checking
- Working with depositors… watch this space

Thank you for listening!

Any questions?

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